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**Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records:
Focus Group Report**

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Abstract

The U.S. Census Bureau's Frames Program seeks to assess public opinion regarding a national demographic frame that would include person-level demographic, social, and economic characteristics for the U.S. population. Working jointly with the Center for Behavioral Science Methods, staff from the Frames Program and RTI International designed a 2-year, multi-mode research study. The research comprises three tasks: (1) develop and test an instrument to assess public perceptions of the use of administrative records, (2) conduct a nationally representative web survey using an address-based probability panel, and (3) conduct focus groups with hard-to-count populations and individuals who participated in the Ipsos web survey.

This report explains the focus group methodology, including a description of the target populations and participant eligibility criteria and the strategies for participant recruitment and screening. Additionally, this report includes the qualitative analysis of the focus group data collected and discusses findings, with potential next step considerations provided to the Census Bureau.

Keywords: public opinion, administrative records

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Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records: Focus Group Report

Final Report

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1. Introduction

The U.S. Census Bureau's Frames Program seeks to assess public opinion regarding a national demographic frame that would include person-level demographic, social, and economic characteristics for the U.S. population. Working jointly with the Center for Behavioral Science Methods, staff from the Frames Program and RTI International designed a 2-year, multi-mode research study. The research comprises three tasks: (1) develop and test an instrument to assess public perceptions of the use of administrative records, (2) conduct a nationally representative web survey using an address-based probability panel, and (3) conduct focus groups with hard-to-count populations and individuals who participated in the Ipsos web survey.

This report explains the focus group methodology, including a description of the target populations and participant eligibility criteria and the strategies for participant recruitment and screening. Additionally, this report includes the qualitative analysis of the focus group data collected and discusses findings, with potential next step considerations provided to the Census Bureau.

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2. Focus Group Methodology

For the Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records (RoPOAR) Subproject 3 Study, RTI International (RTI) conducted 12 focus groups to assess public opinion regarding a national demographic frame that would include person-level demographic, social, and economic characteristics for the U.S. population. These focus groups were conducted with hard-to-count populations and individuals who participated in the Ipsos web survey fielded in Subproject 2.

In preparation for the focus groups, RTI drafted the focus groups' virtual and in-person moderator guides (**Appendices A and B**), with input from the Census Bureau team. Other materials developed included an in-person participant screener (**Appendix C**), virtual and in-person consent forms (**Appendices D and E**), in-person recruitment advertisements (**Appendix F**), a potential frame benefits handout (**Appendix G**), and various email templates to remind participants of the focus groups (**Appendix H**). All materials were developed in English and Spanish.

Moderators and notetakers took part in a training session and were taught the subject matter to have a clear understanding of the focus groups' purpose and process. The training session included the following topics:

- Background and goals of the study
- Sites, dates, and staffing
- Preparation for and activities during and after the groups
- Informed consent, confidentiality, and quality assurance
- Moderation training
- Notetaking training
- Review and practice with moderator's guides

Following the training, staff were given additional time to practice to better understand the moderator guide.

The focus groups were moderated by skilled experienced moderators (with more than 5 years of focus group moderating experience). Moderators maintained a non-judgmental attitude and guided the discussion so that it stayed on course and covered all the topics in the time allotted. Moderators occasionally probed participants to clarify responses and gather additional information as they facilitated the discussion. Notetakers provided on-site logistical support and took notes throughout the focus group sessions.

In total, RTI conducted three virtual focus groups (participants were respondents to the Ipsos survey conducted in Sub Project 2) and nine in-person focus groups, two of which

were completed in Spanish. The distribution and composition of focus group participants are covered in **Table 2.1**.

Table 2.1. Distribution and Composition of Focus Group Participants

FG #	Mode	Characteristic	Language	Government Trust	Location
1	Virtual	General population	English	Low Trust	N/A
2	Virtual	General population	English	Low Trust	N/A
3	Virtual	General population	English	High Trust	N/A
4	In Person	Young White	English	Mixed Trust	Berkeley, CA
5	In Person	General population	English	Low Trust	Berkeley, CA
6	In Person	Hispanic	Spanish	Mixed Trust	RTP, NC
7	In Person	Higher Education	English	Mixed Trust	RTP, NC
8	In Person	Older White	English	Mixed Trust	RTP, NC
9	In Person	Low Education	English	Mixed Trust	Washington, DC
10	In Person	Hispanic	Spanish	Mixed Trust	Chicago, IL
11	In Person	Young African American (AA)	English	Mixed Trust	Chicago, IL
12	In Person	Older African American (AA)	English	Mixed Trust	Chicago, IL

Before inviting participants to take part in the virtual groups, we scored their level of trust in government based on responses they provided to a battery of items in the Ipsos web survey. These items are displayed in **Table 2.2**.

Table 2.2 Ipsos Survey Questions and Response Categories

Ipsos Survey Question	Response Categories
Q5. How concerned are you, if at all, about how the government is using the data it collects about you?	Very concerned Somewhat concerned A little concerned Not at all concerned
Q17. Government agencies already collect data separately about people's jobs, earnings, and participation in government programs but do not always share the data across agencies. To what extent are you in favor of or against combining these data sources?	Strongly in favor of it Somewhat in favor of it Neither in favor nor against it Somewhat against it Strongly against it

Ipsos Survey Question	Response Categories
Q18. The Census Bureau is a government agency that is responsible for producing data about the American people and economy. The next few questions ask about the Census Bureau. Individuals provide information to federal, state, and local agencies when applying for government programs, filing taxes, or completing surveys. The Census Bureau is planning to link this information together to produce statistics. To what extent are you in favor of or against linking information about individuals?	Strongly in favor of it Somewhat in favor of it Neither in favor nor against it Somewhat against it Strongly against it
Q38. In general, how concerned are you about your personal privacy?	Very concerned Somewhat concerned A little concerned Not at all concerned
Q41. To what extent do you agree or disagree: The federal government knows more about me than it needs to.	Strongly agree Somewhat agree Neither agree nor disagree Somewhat disagree Strongly disagree

Based on these responses, participants were classified as having a low or high trust in government institutions if most of their responses leaned in one direction or another. They were then invited to participate in the appropriate group.

For the in-person focus groups, participants were asked four questions on the screening instrument. These questions are presented in **Table 2-3**.

Table 2.3 Online Screening Questions and Response Categories

Online Screening Question	Response Categories
Q6. How concerned are you, if at all, about how <u>companies</u> use the data they collect about you?	Extremely concerned Moderately concerned A little concerned Not at all concerned
Q7. How concerned are you, if at all, about how the <u>government</u> is using the data it collects about you?	Extremely concerned Moderately concerned A little concerned Not at all concerned
Q8. Personally, how much trust do you have in federal statistics in the United States? Would you say that you...	<u>...tend to trust</u> federal statistics <u>...tend not to trust</u> them?

Online Screening Question	Response Categories
Q9. How confident are you in each of these institutions in American society? 1. Newspapers 2. The military 3. The U.S. Census Bureau 4. The U.S. Congress 5. Universities	Extremely confident Very confident Somewhat confident A little confident Not at all confident

Based on these responses, participants were classified as having a low, mixed, or high trust in government institutions after reviewing their responses.

Each focus group was scheduled for 90 minutes. RTI attempted to host approximately 8 to 10 participants per group and each participant was offered a monetary incentive of \$75 (virtual) or \$90 (in-person) as a token of appreciation for participation.

Each focus group was transcribed by a professional transcription firm. The Spanish transcript was then translated into English.

After each focus group was completed, notetakers reviewed their notes along with the audio recording. They provided a summary of findings for each section in the moderator's guide. This identified themes, determined where participants agreed or dissented, and identified key quotes or comments. Notetakers then drafted the individual focus group summary reports. The summary reports were completed in English for the Spanish-speaking groups.

After completing all 12 groups, RTI analyzed the findings for each section of the moderator's guide to identify themes and topics of discussion.

3. Participant Recruitment and Characteristics

RTI developed several recruitment strategies for the in-person focus groups to ensure a sufficient number of participants would take part in the focus groups. These strategies included the following:

- Posting social media advertisements on Craigslist, which is an online community forum. These ads were posted in both English and Spanish.
- Contacting organizations or community groups to introduce the study and partner with them to find participants with the characteristics needed for the group discussion.
- Posting physical flyers (e.g., at community centers, public libraries, bus stops/stations, grocery stores, college student unions, laundromats, etc.)
- Word of mouth advertising / Snowball sampling techniques.

A web-based focus group screening instrument was developed and programmed to determine study eligibility. Interested individuals responding to advertisements were provided a website link to the self-administered screening instrument. Some individuals preferred to be screened by calling the recruitment phone number listed on the advertisement, and the recruiter entered the information directly into the database. This was mostly the preferred mode for Spanish-speaking individuals who called the recruiter directly. Some cohorts were difficult to recruit, like young white and young African American participants, while there were few challenges recruiting other groups. The recruiters continued to recruit participants until there were more people recruited than needed (over recruitment) as a strategy in case we experienced a higher-than-expected no-show rate.

Following screening, eligible participants were selected and invited to participate in the focus groups. After the selected participants agreed to participate, they were sent a confirmation email listing the date, time, and location/invite link of the focus group session.

This research used a convenience, opt-in sample of U.S. adults. We recruited participants who aligned with the geographic, demographic, and language targets for a given group.

For the nine in person focus groups, discussions were held in the following four locations:

- Washington, DC (1 group)
- Berkeley, CA (2 groups)
- Chicago, IL (3 groups)
- Research Triangle Park, NC (3 groups)

Three focus groups were conducted virtually, with those who took part in the Ipsos panel online survey. Of the three groups, two were conducted with participants that were determined to have a low trust in government institutions. This was determined by

analyzing the responses to several of the questions answered in the Ipsos survey, as discussed in **Section 2**. The third group was comprised of participants that were determined to have a high trust in government institutions.

Table 3.1 displays the participant characteristics for the 3 virtual focus groups.

Table 3.1 Virtual Focus Group Participant Characteristics (n=24)

Demographic	Participants
Sex	
Male	13
Female	11
Age	
18-29	6
30-44	5
45-59	3
60+	9
Missing	1
Education	
Less than high school	2
Completed high school	2
Some college	4
Associates	2
Bachelors	8
Post-Bachelors	6
Race	
White	17
Black	5
American Indian/Alaska Native	1
Mixed	1
Ethnicity	
Hispanic	1
Non-Hispanic	23

Table 3.2 displays the participant characteristics for the 9 in-person focus groups.

Table 3.2 In-Person Focus Group Participant Characteristics (*n*=67)

Demographic	Participants
Sex	
Male	37
Female	29
Other	1
Age	
18–29	4
30–44	29
45–59	11
60+	23
Education	
Less than high school	8
Completed high school	6
Some college	18
Associates	9
Bachelors	16
Post-Bachelors	10
Race	
White	37
Black	24
American Indian/Alaska Native	2
Asian	1
Mixed	1
Other	2
Ethnicity	
Hispanic	21
Non-Hispanic	46

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4. Focus Group Results

Each of the following sections, 4.1 through 4.4 align with the in-person moderator's guide. The virtual guide did not cover the potential frame benefits as participants had seen these previously when they responded to the Ipsos survey. The moderator's guides were developed to first ask participants broadly what they thought was meant by "data" and then about government data collection more specifically. In Section 4.2, we began providing participants with some details about the frame, beginning with a broad description and then a more detailed description. Participants were asked how they felt about the database and what questions remained. In Section 4.3 we asked participants about perceived benefits of the frame (in-person groups only) and in Section 4.4, we asked about remaining concerns that participants had.

During analysis it was determined that there were no noticeable differences between the virtual and in-person groups, so they are discussed together in the following sections. The discussion includes focus group identifiers that map to **Table 2.1**, for reference.

4.1 General Government Data Collection

At the beginning of each focus group, participants were asked what they thought of when they heard the term "data." The participants explained that they generally thought of data collected by both government agencies and private companies. Several participants from different focus groups mentioned data as being numbers [FG7 – Higher Education, FG2 – Low Trust], statistics or trends [FG7 – Higher Education, FG12 – Older AA], and social media data [FG5 – Low Trust, FG7 – Higher Education, FG9 – Low Education, FG10 – Hispanic]. Several other participants [FG2 – Low Trust] referred to "information." Some participants [FG4 – Young White] provided examples such as, "Tech companies using data for marketing and to drive sales" and "Numerically measured data." Some participants generally thought of government data such as demographics, providing examples such as age, race, and population density and health care, such as vaccine status. Other participants [FG5 – Low Trust] thought of "statistics" and "video data." One participant thought of "surveillance." The participants explained that some companies collect and use data on customers, such as Google and Meta.

Participants from one Spanish-speaking group [FG6 – Hispanic] understood "data" as personal information, such as names, date of birth, or addresses. The participants mentioned that these data are collected when they perform commercial transactions and when they complete government forms, such as the decennial census and migration registries (when entering the country). One participant explained, "If you enter as a tourist, (the government) will have all the information. I entered around 22 years ago, and the government doesn't miss anything, all my information is there, the information that you provide and the one you don't provide, they also know it."

Some participants [FG8 – Older White] focused on their feelings toward the collection of data, either negatively or positively. One participant explained, “I’m not comfortable at all, it’s overwhelming, too much of it. I don’t have a cell phone. There is so much out there with identity theft. I try to disengage from it.” Another participant commented, “I’m on the other side of the coin. I think there’s a wealth of information out there; part of that is for business. I’m always on my phone. I’m always looking up things. I think there’s a lot of benefits.” A few participants [FG9 – Low Education] thought about data collected online and explained, “Data is the new oil. It’s a commodity that’s valuable to big companies. Buying information to learn how to sell” and “Everyone can reach it. It’s all online and on a cloud. Anyone can get it and mess my life up.”

Participants were then asked whether they thought about data collected by government or by private companies. The participants [FG1 – Low Trust, FG2 – Low Trust, FG4 – Young White, FG7 – Higher Education, FG8 – Older White] generally thought of data being collected by both government agencies and private companies such as Meta and Google. Several participants from other focus groups [FG2 – Low Trust, FG4 – Young White, FG7 – Higher Education, FG8 – Older White] explained that data are being collected from you all the time, both voluntarily and nonvoluntarily. This is done through the completion of government forms where one provides data. Data that are not voluntarily provided include data from computers, mobile devices, social media and purchasing data from commercial companies [FG2 – Low Trust]. One participant explained, “They make you think we have a choice when you look at those agreements that you must complete or agree to before using a service... but I have never seen an option where if you don’t agree to the condition, you can still use the service” [FG2 – Low Trust]. Another participant [FG4 – Young White] explained, “I think they are listening. The government is listening to your personal information like Alexa.” Private companies collect data on you and, in turn, use it for marketing. Another participant [FG4 – Young White] commented, “A lot of companies will ask for feedback and there are some ways they do it using algorithms based on what you click on that give you information.” After thinking about private companies, this participant thought about government data collection, explaining, “We don’t know how much the government has access or what they are collecting.” A few participants [FG8 – Older White] held similar concerns. One participant [FG8 – Older White] explained, “You have a social security number, so they have data on you” while another participant [FG8 – Older White] explained, “It’s not the data, it’s the way it’s been utilized. I have no ability to control what it is used for. I don’t like to lose control. It really annoys me that there are companies or government agencies that know about me more.”

When asked about types of data that they thought companies and government collect and how these data are obtained, the participants offered a wide range of things that are collected about people, including the following:

1. Data provided when filling out an application for a job [FG1 – Low Trust, FG7 – Higher Education, FG11 – Young AA, FG12 – Older AA]
2. Things being collected by the IRS, driver's license, credit reports, purchases [FG1 – Low Trust, FG11 – Young AA]
3. Data collected through social media [FG2 – Low Trust, FG7 – Higher Education, FG8 – Older White, FG11 – Young AA, FG12 – Older AA]
4. Legal documents, federal forms (applications to benefits, taxes), studies that collect data, users' activity in computers, and third-party vendor data [FG2 – Low Trust]
5. Completion of paper or online forms, where they state their personal information (referring to name, date of birth, address) [FG2 – Low Trust]
6. People tracking them and listening to their conversations over the phone. One participant [FG2 – Low Trust] explained, "When it comes to government and tracking you and your movements, its eerie to think about it because there are cameras everywhere [...], and your cell phone is connected to towers, so they can always triangulate it (other participants show signals of agreement) [...]" "I don't think there is much privacy anymore. I think it is all out there, everything that is on your phone, everything that is in your computer. So, I guess the more we use that stuff, the more information they have."
7. Social security number [FG3 – High Trust]
8. Personal health data (in regard to signing up for service such as 23 and me) [FG4 – Young White, FG12 – Older AA]
9. Data provided when you register a car (e.g., name, age, ethnicity, physical address) [FG4 – Young White]
10. Online search or shopping habits on Amazon, CVS, Target [FG4 – Young White, FG8 – Older White, FG11 – Young AA, FG12 – Older AA]
11. Data collected through security cameras and facial recognition [FG4 – Young White]
12. License plate readers [FG4 – Young White]
13. Data sharing agreements when you load a new app on your phone [FG5 – Low Trust, FG9 – Low Education]
14. Law firms [FG5 – Low Trust]
15. Financial institutions [FG5 – Low Trust, FG8 – Older White]
16. Data provided when applying for a credit card [FG6 – Hispanic, FG8 – Older White]
17. Data provided on voter registration forms [FG7 – Higher Education]
18. Data provided when presenting passports to TSA when travelling [FG7 – Higher Education]
19. Change of address through the Post Office [FG7 – Higher Education]
20. Government purchasing data collected by private companies [FG7 – Higher Education, FG11 – Young AA, FG12 – Older AA]
21. Government gets data from people when they file their taxes [FG8 – Older White]
22. Data provided when you apply for a mortgage [FG8 – Older White, FG12 – Older AA]

- 23. The rewards card you apply for at the grocery store [FG9 – Low Education]: One participant [FG9 – Low Education] explained, “Sign up for credit cards, sign up for store rewards, all information go[es] into one huge system”
- 24. The Dark Web [FG9 – Low Education]
- 25. When applying for an apartment lease [FG11 – Young AA]
- 26. When purchasing insurance [FG11 – Young AA]

When asked about the level of control people have over the data collected about them, the participants generally felt that they had little to no control. The participants felt that data are being collected every day, everywhere, and that this is a byproduct of living in an advanced technological society. One participant [FG3 – High Trust] explained, “Once you are online you have no control. They give you the illusion that you have control, but you don’t really.” The Low Trust groups felt strongest about this issue and their lack of control. A Spanish-speaking participant [FG6 – Hispanic] explained, “Google is already automated, and they are listening to you, as well as the government, that is, there is no privacy at all, they listen to the conversations we have. If you want privacy in your room, you have to leave the phone in the living room.”

When probed whether participants felt they had more control over government collection of data or data collected from private companies, most participants responded with “neither.” However, one participant [FG3 – High Trust] felt it was harder for government agencies to access data compared with private companies, explaining, “In theory government is more constrained by laws compared to private companies. I think this (collection of data) may be outsourced to private companies. Companies can run buck wild, and the government can piggyback off them.” Some participants [FG3 – High Trust] generally had a favorable opinion of having the government use the data appropriately, especially compared with private companies. Other participants [FG9 – Low Education] felt they have less control over data that the government collects compared with private companies’ data collection. They felt this was the case because they file taxes and have connections through Social Security Numbers and birth certificates. As a result, the data are there and available if the government wants to access them.

When asked how people can benefit from the data government has about people and their communities, most participants provided examples of how the community benefits. At the community level, participants thought of benefits such as the proper allocation of resources and analysis used to understand local immigration trends [FG1 – Low Trust, FG10 – Hispanic]. Other participants thought of allocation of resources and funding to schools and congressional allocation of representatives [FG3 – High Trust, FG7 – Higher Education], city planning and public transportation [FG4 – Young White, FG7 – Higher Education, FG9 – Low Education, FG12 – Older AA]. One participant [FG6 – Hispanic] explained, “I believe there are benefits, because at times the government wants to know how many people live in specific areas, and what the needs are in those areas: streets with holes, electricity, not

enough security, more shopping centers needed. It will depend on how many people live in certain areas.” Another participant [FG11 – Young AA] thought of ways the government uses data in the allocation of funds for social services such as SNAP benefits and emergency funding in the event of a natural disaster. Another participant [FG12 – Older AA] added, “They might try to improve your community and add things. They might talk to people and realize that it might be a [food] desert area and that stores or restaurants are needed. If there are a lot of kids in the area, they might think, let’s put a store over there or a community center.” This focus on community benefits were also found in the cognitive interviews, with participants finding community benefits more concrete than individual benefits.

4.2 Describing/Understanding the Frame

During the next section of the focus group, participants were first provided a general description of the frame (**Table 4.1**).

Table 4.1 General Description of the Frame

The Census Bureau plans to build a new database about people that combines information from other government agencies, government surveys you may have answered in the past, and private companies. The database would only be used to produce statistics.

Participants were then asked for their overall reactions, types of data they thought might be included in the frame, any questions participants had after hearing the description, potential benefits of the frame development, the purpose of the frame, and how easy it was to understand the concept.

After this initial discussion, participants in the focus groups were provided a more detailed description of the frame (**Table 4.2**).

Table 4.2 Detailed Description of the Frame

I’m going to give you some more information about this database. This database would link together information about individuals. Some examples are age, sex, race, ethnicity, education, income. The data would come from sources such as the Social Security Administration, IRS, and government programs such as SNAP and WIC.
--

This detailed description included additional information about the types of data that would be included and the sources of these data. Participants were again asked their overall reactions, whether they felt more comfortable after hearing more about the frame, and their feelings about linking data from private companies.

Most of the group participants had negative reactions to the idea of the Census Bureau building a new database combining information from several sources. The most positive reaction came from one of the Spanish-speaking focus groups [FG5 – Low Trust]. The main

positive benefit from this Spanish-speaking group was that the database could provide better population counts, which could include people who may not complete the decennial census, such as undocumented Latinx people. These Spanish-speaking participants [FG6 – Hispanic] expressed positive reactions when hearing the more detailed description of the frame. The participants explained that the information included in these examples was already being provided voluntarily, so they did not see a problem with it being linked together.

Participants from the Low Trust [FG1 – Low Trust, FG2 – Low Trust, FG5 – Low Trust] and Low Education [FG9 – Low Education] groups had the most negative reactions to the new frame. For example, one participant [FG2 – Low Trust] explained, “In no way, shape, or form am I going to give the government every single piece of information about me, and then have a database on every single person.” Participants from the Low Trust groups had many questions about how the database would work, what the benefits would be, and how their data would be kept secure. Concerns raised by these groups will be further discussed in **Section 4.4**.

Participants mostly thought that the concept of the database was easy to understand, but some participants wanted more information. One group [FG11 – Young AA] emphasized that although the concept was easy to understand, they did not understand the purpose of the database. One participant [FG7 – Higher Education] thought it would be a good idea to have a phone number available for people to call to ask questions. Other participants [FG9 – Low Education; FG12 – Older AA] thought that only people with specialized knowledge about databases or statistics would be able to fully understand this complicated idea. Four participants from one focus group [FG2 – Low Trust] agreed that people would not really care enough to try to understand because they have more pressing priorities, such as “living paycheck to paycheck.”

There was some confusion over whether the Census Bureau had already established the database described in the frame. Some participants believed that the Census Bureau or the government at large already has a central database. These participants questioned how the description provided in the frame is different from what they already believe is happening or should be happening. A couple of participants from one focus group [FG7 – Higher Education] felt the government should have already been creating a single, central database by working together with other agencies to obtain the information they need. One participant from another focus group [FG3 – High Trust] expressed amusement that the government has yet to create this database.

Three participants from one focus group [FG11 – Young AA] questioned how this database would be different from what is already happening. One of them [FG11 – Young AA] speculated, “If they aren’t acquiring the information themselves, I guess they are outsourcing it versus doing it themselves like they were doing previously? They had people

coming to your door asking you questions but now they will get the information from other sources?" Another participant [FG11 – Young AA] wondered, "Maybe they feel they aren't getting enough information from the people, so they are having to go to the companies? They could be getting a lack of data, so they have to go this route." Two participants from another focus group [FG12 – Older AA] also thought that Census Bureau was already collecting data in the way the frame described. One participant [FG12 – Older AA] explained, "when they take our information, they have the different age brackets, different income. I feel like they're doing that now." Another participant [FG12 – Older AA] reiterated that they had previously "assumed this is already happening in one form or another." Relatedly, one participant from a Low Trust focus group [FG1 – Low Trust] felt this database was not needed because the Census Bureau already has all the data they need.

Participants were asked their thoughts about having the Census Bureau lead the frame development effort rather than other government agencies. Most participants had a favorable view of the Census Bureau and believe that it is a non-threatening, trusted government agency. Many thought that the Census Bureau was the best agency to lead this initiative and that it was aligned with the mission of the Census Bureau to monitor the population of the United States. Participants saw the Census Bureau as a respected institution known for helping people. Almost all participants thought that the Census Bureau would be the better agency compared to the IRS to lead this effort. For example, one participant [FG8 – Older White] stated "[the] Census Bureau is a fairly innocuous group, better than the IRS." Another participant [FG4 – Young White] stated "The Census bureau is slightly less nefarious [than other government agencies]." Even one of the Low Trust groups [FG5 – Low Trust] had a positive impression of the Census Bureau leading this effort. One participant [FG5- Low Trust] stated, "The Census is supposed to be about collecting data about people and communities. Better than a negative agency such as the IRS." This theme of a positive reaction to and high trust for the Census Bureau was also observed during the cognitive interviews completed as part of Subproject 1.

However, a few participants in one focus group [FG11 -Young AA] thought that the IRS would be better because people may be more willing to share their information. Furthermore, they thought that people were scared of the IRS and they would therefore be more likely to share their information with the Census Bureau than the IRS. Some participants [FG11- Young AA; F12- Older AA] did not think that the agency leading the effort mattered since multiple agencies would be working together to share information. According to one participant [FG11- Young AA], "I don't think it matters to me who leads it – the Census or a different agency. They are going to be working together to get the information anyway."

Some Spanish-speaking participants [FG6 – Hispanic, FG10 – Hispanic] had concerns about how the Census Bureau may use the database to monitor or track undocumented persons, echoing concerns that the same Spanish-speaking group had about participating in the

decennial census earlier in the discussion. For low-trust groups [FG1 – Low Trust, FG2 – Low Trust, FG5 – Low Trust], the government agency is a moot point; they object to the database entirely and it does not matter which agency leads the effort. As one participant [FG2 – Low Trust] explained, “From the consensus in this group, specifically, it just sounds like we don’t trust the government here. Doesn’t matter what question you ask; we are going to say no.”

When asked why the Census Bureau would want to create this type of database, participants had somewhat vague ideas about what the reason might be. Some participants across various focus groups [FG4 – Young White; FG8 – Older White; FG12 – Older AA] mentioned ideas such as saving money or increasing efficiency without providing any concrete examples. For example, one participant [FG8 – Older White] stated, “It sounds like they want to centralize, and it could be time saving.”

Several participants mentioned increased data accuracy with a few different ideas about how that may happen. One participant [FG12 – Older AA] thought that the Census Bureau may currently have inaccurate or incomplete data and combining sources from various agencies would help improve the data Census Bureau already has. Another participant [FG6 – Hispanic] thought that combining data would provide the Census Bureau with access to data for people who may not complete the decennial census, such as undocumented persons. One participant [FG11 – Young AA] thought that pulling the same data from multiple sources could help the Census Bureau confirm that they had the most accurate and correct data.

Two participants thought that the COVID-19 pandemic may be one reason why the Census Bureau was interested in creating the frame. One participant [FG11 – Young AA] thought that the Census Bureau was limited with data collection during the COVID-19 pandemic and needed to bolster the data they missed over the past few years. Another participant [FG12 – Older AA] echoed this idea, stating, “During COVID, the Census wasn’t getting the information they needed.”

A few participants provided additional examples of reasons they thought the Census Bureau would create this database. One participant [FG9 – Low Education] hoped that the information in the database would be used for “good” stating, “My hope is that the information is being used for good. Not being used to enforce, look for illegal immigrants, harboring more people. Not big brother spying for me. It’s my duty to provide information to help people. My hope is that it is used to reduce water bills, reduce traffic, create public transit.” Another [FG11 – Young AA] thought that the information might be used for safety reasons, such as to find or stop criminals who pose a threat to communities. Another [FG11 – Young AA] thought that the information could be used by someone interested in tracing their own heritage or genealogy. Some Spanish-speaking participants [FG10 – Hispanic;

FG6 – Hispanic] were unable to think of any reason why the Census Bureau would want to create the frame.

After being shown the general description of the frame, participants were asked to list the agencies they thought the Census Bureau might get data from. The IRS was the agency most groups thought the Census Bureau would get data from (mentioned in 9 out of 12 groups), followed by the Social Security Administration (mentioned in 5 out of 12 groups). Other agencies mentioned in multiple groups were the DMV, the FBI, Department of Health and Human Services, and welfare agencies (including WIC, SNAP, HUD, and Medicaid/Medicare). Other state and federal agencies mentioned only one time included the Department of Transportation, Department of Treasury, Department of Justice, Federal Bureau of Prisons, Veteran's Affairs, Department on Aging, Immigration and Customs Enforcement, the military in general, and Department of Death Certificates. It was unclear whether some of these agencies actually exist, but they were provided as examples.

Some participants [FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA; FG9 – Low Education] thought that medical records from private doctor's offices or mental health records may be included in the database. However, one participant [FG11 – Young AA] explained that primary care provider offices cannot give information about people to the Census because of the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA). One participant [FG9 – Low Education] believed that nothing would be off limits in terms of data accessible within the proposed database, explaining that this included their "health, dental, age, race, and income."

The participants had questions and concerns when asked how they felt about linking data from private companies. Reactions to the idea of linking private company data was more negative across all groups than linking government information alone. One participant [FG8 – Older White] stated, "I have no problem centralizing data from government agencies only, but the problem would be private companies."

Some participants had concerns around privacy and government overreach. For example, one participant [FG7 – Higher Education] commented, "It means government buying data from private companies, it's just another privacy sink where we're losing more of our privacy to government, and they've figured out a way to do it legally." Another participant [FG10 – Hispanic] stated, "[The government does] not have to know if I have good or bad credit score, or if I've paid my car. There is information that is strictly mine [...], they need to limit it to what they need. They don't have to have access, that is my privacy."

Another participant concerned about private companies [FG1 – Low Trust] added, "[Private companies] need to step out of the government; they need to be away from this conversation." Some other participants were suspicious of the motives of private companies and worried that they do not have public interest as the main goal [FG9 – Low Education; FG11 – Young AA; FG2 – Low Trust]. Some worried that the information from private

companies may not be very accurate [FG9 – Low Education]. Many participants want a clear separation between government activities and private companies.

The focus group participants questioned whether private companies would have access to the database and were concerned that private companies could profit from the database [FG6 – Hispanic; FG10 – Hispanic]. Some participants had questions about their privacy, which private companies would be involved, what data would be purchased (such as credit scores or debt), and who would make the decisions to link additional data. Some participants [FG9 – Low Education] were unsure what it meant for the database to link to their address using data from private companies.

A few participants expressed neutral or positive reactions to the idea of data provided by private companies. One participant [FG9 – Low Education] did not offer strong opinions but thought the government having their data combined with private companies' data would not necessarily be bad because these would only be statistics so it would just be another source of information. This participant [FG9 – Low Education] also shared that getting another source of information could be a good thing, and they hoped that the government would have their best interests at heart. Some of the participants in the Low Education focus group agreed that Google has up-to-date, accurate data so it would make sense for the Census Bureau to partner with Google. Another participant from a different focus group [FG7 – Higher Education] stated, "More people are using more information from Amazon than from Census, and it could potentially be more accurate. It could be broader categories that the government could use, like ethnicity. Statistically it could help out the outcome." These positive reactions were very limited and even groups that had a positive impression of the frame [FG6 – Hispanic] disliked the idea of data from private companies being involved.

The main questions that participants had about the frame included the reason or purpose for the database, data accuracy, data security, the benefits, and the consent process, presented in **Table 4.3**. Table 4.3 presents the most frequently asked questions about the frame, presenting the themes, specific questions asked, and number of focus groups in which each theme came up during discussion. We did not identify any patterns across the focus groups for the types of questions that came up because of the focus group characteristics, such as low trust or higher education.

As one participant [FG7 – Higher Education] stated, "For what purpose is this? How will they utilize it? Who will have access to it? I have a lot of questions." Another participant [FG5 – Low Trust] asked, "Why do you feel the need to do it? What do you expect to accomplish? How will it benefit the population?" One participant [FG1 – Low Trust] said they wanted to know "What data is being collected? Why is it needed? What problem is it actually solving?"

Table 4.3 Most Frequently Asked Questions about the Frame

Theme	Questions	Number of Focus Groups
Reason/purpose for the database	- What is the purpose? - What is the goal? - How will the data be used? - What is the point?	12
Data security	- Is the data secure? - What will be done to maintain data privacy? - How will the database be protected against hackers? - Can the database be hacked? - Who will have access to the database? - Can the database be misused? - Is there Personally identifiable information (PII) included in the database? - Are the data anonymous? - How will the data be securely shared between agencies?	8
Data accuracy	- Are the data accurate? - How will inaccurate information be corrected? - How often will updates be made to the data? - How can I verify whether the information about me is accurate in the database?	6
Benefits	- How does the database benefit people? - How does the database benefit me, specifically?	5
Consent process	- Can I opt out of the database? - Can I choose whether my data are shared? - Will I be notified about my data in the database and who it is shared with? - How will people be informed about the database?	4

Several of these questions also emerged during the cognitive interviews completed in Subproject 1, especially the need for more details about the purpose of the database and the consent process. Throughout the cognitive interviews, participants expressed the desire for more information about the reasons Census Bureau wanted to create a central database. Additionally, participants in the cognitive interviews explained that their opinion about being in favor or against combining their data and using their data for other purposes relied on whether they would be able to provide explicit consent at the point of data collection. The concept of whether they can opt out of the database was raised frequently.

In addition to the frequently asked questions, some participants also had general logistics questions about the database, including how the database will be created and how the information would be shared between agencies [FG9 – Low Education; FG12 – Older AA].

Several participants [FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA] asked questions about how far back the data included in the database would go; they wanted to understand the amount of data and the level of detail that may be in the database.

After hearing about the first, more general description of the frame, participants had more questions about the types of data that would be included and whether the data would include identifying information. A few participants [FG6 – Hispanic] wondered which agencies would be providing the data. The first more general description sparked questions about the word “statistics,” which some participants [FG12 – Older AA; FG4 – Young White] did not understand. These participants questioned what the word “statistics” meant and how the statistics would be used. The description also brought up some questions about the use of private company data and participants wondered which companies and what kind of data may be included [FG11 – Young AA; FG5 – Low Trust].

After being provided the more detailed description of the frame, participants continued to have questions about the purpose of the database and how the data would be used. The additional details provided about the data sources and the data did not provide enough information for participants. Three participants in the higher education group [FG7 – Higher Education] had questions around why data around race would need to be included.

4.3 Benefits of the Frame

The participants were asked about the perceived benefits from the general and detailed descriptions of the frame. Many participants could easily see community benefits related to the creation of the database. Participants could see the benefit of creating the database to better understand individual communities and allocate resources more efficiently [FG4 – Young White; FG6 – Hispanic; FG7 – Higher Education; FG10 – Hispanic; FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA; FG3 – High Trust]. Other community benefits included funding for schools, parks, medical centers or hospitals, and public street maintenance. Four focus groups [FG10 – Hispanic; FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA; FG6 – Hispanic] discussed the possibility that the frame could help individuals receive government services or unemployment.

Participants had a harder time thinking about personal benefits and many could think of no personal benefits when explicitly asked, even when the community benefits were clear [FG10 – Hispanic; FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA]. This theme of more concrete community benefits was also observed during the cognitive interviews completed in Subproject 1. Other benefits participants mentioned once are presented in the table below (**Table 4.4**).

Table 4.4 Additional Benefits of the Frame

Benefit	Focus Group
The database is an alternative to sending census enumerators out in the field	FG9 – Low Education
Allows for updates to data outside of the decennial census	FG6 – Hispanic
Potential health benefits	FG9 – Low Education
Notification if someone qualifies for a government program	FG9 – Low Education
Planning in general	FG4 – Young White
Efficiencies of multiple government agencies working together	FG5 – Low Trust

However, some participants doubted there were any benefits to the proposed frame, and some wondered if the community benefits that others talked about would really happen. One focus group [FG8 – Older White] was unclear whether there would be local community level benefits from a federally sponsored database. Participants in the Low Trust groups [FG1 – Low Trust, FG2 – Low Trust, FG5 – Low Trust] had a difficult time thinking of any benefits and more of these Low Trust participants said there were no benefits.

After reviewing the general and detailed description of the frame, participants in the in-person focus groups were then shown descriptions of potential benefits from the creation of the frame. These five potential benefit statements are presented in **Table 4.5**. Virtual focus groups were not shown the benefits of the frame because these groups were sourced from the Ipsos survey respondents, and these descriptions were already included in the Ipsos survey.

Table 4.5 Five Potential Frame Benefits

1	Developing this database could mean that you are asked to fill out surveys less often because your information is already available.
2	Developing this database could help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money.
3	Developing this database could help your local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently.
4	Developing this database would mean that information and statistics about the country are more accurate.
5	Developing this database would help complete survey responses when information is missing.

Benefit 1: Fewer Surveys

Benefit 1 was not a compelling benefit for most participants, with many seeing it as negative. Participants across four focus [FG4 – Young White; FG7 – Higher Education; FG9 – Low Education; FG12 – Older AA] groups saw the first benefit as negative because they believed it was important to fill out surveys to ensure that the information the government has access to is as up-to-date and accurate as possible. Three participants in the Low

Education focus group [FG9 – Low Education] were thinking about the decennial census and worried that data within the database would be outdated and inaccurate when surveys are collected less often. Three participants had similar sentiments in the Older African American focus group [FG12 – Older AA]. These three participants pointed out that filling out surveys less often could hurt you in that the information on file may be outdated. In the words of one participant [FG12 – Older AA], “It’s good to be able to re-up information with the government on where you are at in life...your current status.” This sentiment was echoed by another participant [FG12 – Older AA] who said, “I like the idea, but I would still want to update my information.” The other two focus groups [FG4 – Young White; FG7 – Higher Education] echoed similar worries about the accuracy of information being diminished if surveys were filled out less often. One participant from a Low Trust group [FG2 – Low Trust] mentioned that limiting the number of surveys someone takes would remove their right or opportunity to provide an opinion. Another participant from a Spanish-speaking group [FG6 – Hispanic] thought that it was beneficial for people to fill out surveys so that they can share their ideas and opinions, especially when there may be issues that need to be resolved.

In addition to seeing fewer surveys as a negative, other participants were simply unclear as to how the completion of fewer surveys would be a concrete benefit. A few participants across a few focus groups said they did not mind filling out surveys [FG4 – Young White; FG9 – Low Education], while others mentioned that even when they receive surveys, they do not typically fill them out [FG6 – Hispanic]. Two participants [FG4 – Young White] did not feel like Benefit 1 was much of a benefit because they do not mind providing survey data. Another participant [FG6 – Hispanic] mentioned that she gets surveys but never completes them, so it was unclear to her whether Benefit 1 was truly a benefit. One participant [FG8 – Older White] also mentioned that surveys are normally optional anyway and that few people fill out surveys even if they receive them. Participants from two focus groups also discussed that there were not very many surveys anyway and they struggled to see Benefit 1 as a benefit. Participants in one focus groups [FG11 – Young AA] commented that they do not feel like they fill out a lot of government surveys currently and therefore they did not see this as a positive feature or benefit of the database. One participant from another focus group [FG8 – Older White] thought that it is not inconvenient to fill out surveys and that there are not so many of them.

This idea that Benefit 1 was not a compelling benefit was also discovered during the cognitive interviews. The cognitive interview data illustrated that many people were aware only of the decennial census that they complete once every 10 years. They were unaware of other surveys run by the Census Bureau and did not see a clear benefit of completing fewer surveys. This finding was replicated in some of the focus groups, with some participants thinking the surveys mentioned in Benefit 1 referred only to the decennial census [FG9 – Low Education; FG12 – Older AA].

Other participants were confused about what surveys Benefit 1 was referring to, with participants from two focus groups [FG8 – Older White; FG11 – Young AA] asking questions to understand more about the surveys. Other focus group participants assumed that the surveys mentioned in Benefit 1 referenced forms in applying for benefits such as WIC and SNAP [FG3 – High Trust] or in completing passport applications [FG9 – Low Education]. These participants believed the database would reduce their paperwork burden when applying for benefits or securing a passport and were in support of this improvement. Additionally, one focus group [FG10 – Hispanic] struggled to understand Benefit 1 at all. Regardless of the moderator's effort, some participants [FG10 – Hispanic] did not see this as a perceived benefit.

Although many of the participant reactions to Benefit 1 were negative or uncertain, a few participants did see it as a benefit. Two participants from the Higher Education focus group [FG7 – Higher Education] did think it was a benefit to fill out fewer surveys but did not expand on why they felt that way. Two participants in the Older African American focus group agreed that Benefit 1 was a benefit. One participant [FG12 – Older AA] remarked, "Sometimes they give us surveys and it's a lot of paperwork. Sometimes you get frustrated because it's so much. If it is less, people are more inclined to fill it out." According to one participant [FG12 – Older AA], "...anything that could streamline our process like that is beneficial."

Benefit 2: Better Use of Taxpayer Money

Some participants were able to see Benefit 2 as a perceived benefit in the Young White group [FG4 – Young White], one of the Spanish-speaking groups [FG6 – Hispanic], the Older White group [FG8 – Older White], and the Young African American group [FG11 – Young AA]. These participants thought the database could positively impact community services such as parks, schools, day care centers, health services, and general infrastructure. For example, one participant [FG11 – Young AA] shared that it would be a benefit or good thing if this database could help social service agencies make better use of taxpayer money. This participant continued explaining that the database could "...help focus in on whatever the need is for specific areas rather than thinking that everyone needs everything." Two participants thought the database could help make sure that those who needed social services could receive them [FG5 – Low Trust; FG7 – Higher Education]. One participant [FG7 – Higher Education] said that having more access to people's data and targeting more marginalized people to develop social programs would be a way that the database could help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money. Another participant [FG5 – Low Trust] from a Low Trust group had a more unfavorable view of this benefit, stating "Maybe it is a good way to make sure people who are getting services deserve them. Not waste money. But I don't like it." In addition to the participants who were able to see Benefit 2 as a benefit, most participants in the Young White group [FG4 – Young White] had a neutral reaction to this benefit.

Although participants were able to see Benefit 2 as a more concrete benefit than Benefit 1, they still had doubts about the veracity of the claim. Several focus groups [FG7 – Higher Education; FG8 – Older White; FG12 – Older AA] laughed aloud when reading the benefit, reflecting their doubts as to whether the government would be able to use taxpayer money effectively. Participants from the Older African American group explained that this database should help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money but were not convinced that it would. One participant [FG12 – Older AA] shared, “In a perfect world, that could work but we have dirty politicians. The money comes to Chicago and doesn’t quite make it to Chicago, or it’s only designated for one area and ends up in another area.” Another participant [FG12 – Older AA] agreed and expressed “I hope this is true. Sometimes we know that money disappears in government though sometimes.” These sentiments were echoed in the Older White group [FG8 – Older White], where one participant commented, “I doubt that. I question that big time.” Similarly, in the Higher Education group [FG7 – Higher Education], two participants did not agree with Benefit 2, implying that the government does not make good use of taxpayer money anyway. Three other participants [FG7 – Higher Education] had questions, such as where the money would go and whether this database will actually help the government use taxpayer money better.

Some participants had a stronger negative reaction to Benefit 2 because they believe that the government “always wastes money” and that making better use of taxpayer money is “impossible.” One participant [FG4 – Young White] did not like the idea of Benefit 2, because they felt government wastes money, explaining, “Look at military allocations of tax dollars. They waste a lot of money. To say taxpayer money is better allocated, it’s a moot point, because we already waste a lot of money.” When probed about ways the database could help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money, one participant [FG8 – Older White] said, “That’s not what their mission is, it’s just for their benefit.” Another participant in the same group [FG8- Older White] explained, “I don’t ever see my perception ever changed about this. I don’t see anything positive about it, it’s an embarrassment.” Participants in one of the Low Trust groups [FG2 – Low Trust] agreed with these sentiments and did not believe this would be a benefit; they believed that better use of taxpayer money cannot be guaranteed and that there is already too much government spending.

When asked about the types of “government agencies” they thought about when reviewing this perceived benefit, participants provided the following examples:

- IRS [FG5 – Low Trust; FG6 – Hispanic; FG7 – Higher Education]
- State, County, and local government agencies [FG8 – Older White; FG5 – Low Trust; FG12 – Older AA]
- Social Security Administration [FG5 – Low Trust; FG7 – Higher Education]
- U.S. Food and Drug Administration [FG7 – Higher Education]
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention [FG7 – Higher Education]

- Military [FG8 – Older White]
- Social service agencies [FG11 – Young AA]
- Politicians in general [FG11 – Young AA]
- Federal government agencies [FG12 – Older AA]
- Department of transportation [FG4 – Young White]

Benefit 3: Deliver Services More Efficiently

Benefit 3 was perceived as one of the most concrete benefits for participants and was described, unprompted, when thinking about potential benefits of the frame (as discussed earlier in **Section 4.2.**) For example, one participant from a Low Trust group [FG5 – Low Trust] had an unexpected positive reaction to Benefit 3, stating “If anything is beneficial – benefits is money. Services is cleaning up and fixing potholes. That would be great!”

When thinking of the types of services and benefits that could be delivered more efficiently, participants mentioned the following:

- Schools [FG7 – Higher Education; FG6 – Hispanic; FG9 – Low Education; FG10 – Hispanic]
- Access to health services [FG7 – Higher Education; FG6 – Hispanic; FG9 – Low Education; FG10 – Hispanic]
- General community services or needs [FG5 – Low Trust; FG6 – Hispanic; FG8 – Older White]
- Road infrastructure maintenance, such as fixing potholes or repaving [FG5 – Low Trust; FG8 – Older White]
- Food stamps or food in general [FG9 – Low Education; FG10 – Hispanic]
- City planning [FG4 – Young White]
- Unemployment benefits [FG5 – Low Trust]
- Better living conditions in general [FG6 – Hispanic]
- Public transportation [FG7 – Higher Education]

In addition to these more specific examples, participants from two groups [FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA] thought that the database could be used to identify community needs and improve allocation of funding. Another participant [FG4 – Young White] thought that the database would help provide more up-to-date information than was collected during the decennial census every 10 years. This participant stated, “During COVID, a lot of people lost their jobs and moved to other areas. There was an influx of people and families. School districts might expand, and others are reduced. That is usually collected every 10 years during the Census, so this [developing the database] might be more efficient to gather it quicker.”

Participants in three focus groups [FG6 – Hispanic; FG8 – Older White; FG12 – Older AA] explained that they trusted local government compared with other government agencies. One participant [FG8 – Older White] explained, “I do believe in the local government because that’s where you feel it, like paving roads, keeping running water, things that make your community work.” Participants in one of the Spanish-speaking groups echoed this idea; these participants were in favor of the idea of providing more information to local governments, so that the local government could better understand their community needs. This finding around higher trust for local governments was also established in the cognitive interviews. The cognitive interview participants indicated that they were more willing to share data with their local government compared with the federal government, because they believed they could receive more direct benefits.

Although reactions to Benefit 3 were mostly positive, some participants felt unsure as to how the database could improve efficiency. In one of the Low Trust groups [FG5 – Low Trust] some participants questioned the need for a database to understand local issues. One participant [FG5 – Low Trust] stated, “We don’t need a database to know that there are homeless people and that the infrastructure is failing.” Other participants from several focus groups [FG7 – Higher Education; FG10 – Hispanic; FG2 – Low Trust] thought that this benefit should already be happening. One participant [FG7 – Higher Education] said, “We should have already been finding ways for all those different services to be talking to each other, this is something we should be working at already.” One participant from a Spanish-speaking group [FG10 – Hispanic] mentioned that she believed that these benefits were already in place and that the local government were already providing these types of benefits, so she did not perceive a difference with what is already the status quo. Additionally, participants from one of the Low Trust groups [FG2 – Low Trust] felt that the government already had these data. As a result, these participants [FG2 – Low Trust] were not convinced that Benefit 3 would be a benefit.

Some participants felt that Benefit 3 was worded awkwardly, insinuating that these benefits were not guaranteed. In one Low Trust group [FG5 – Low Trust] participants focused on the phrase “could help” in the benefit statement. They noted that this was not reassuring, one participant [FG5 – Low Trust] elaborating, “I’m struggling with ‘could’ help. Can it be a promise? Make it credible and put your initials on it.” This idea was echoed in one of the Spanish-speaking groups [FG10 – Hispanic] where one participant mentioned that there is no guarantee that these data will create these benefits. Furthermore, participants in the Older African American group [FG12 – Older AA] had doubts that the database would help their local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently.

Some participants struggled to understand how a federal database could help improve the delivery of local government services and benefits. One participant [FG4 – Young White] commented, “I am just not convinced that the database will help in that regard. Sometimes smaller scale is better way to go.” Another participant [FG8 – Older White] said, “I think

we're talking about a federal agency like the Census Bureau creating a national database and I suspect that local governments aren't always going to benefit about this. A local database makes more sense."

Two participants wanted to know more about which services and benefits would be improved. After reviewing Benefit 3, one participant [FG11 – Young AA] asked for clarification on what is meant by "services." One participant in another group [FG6 – Hispanic] mentioned that he would like to know the specific community benefits he would receive because of this database. This comment also echoes previous questions about what personal benefits exist from the database.

Benefit 4: More Accurate Statistics

Benefit 4 was not as clear of a benefit for many participants. Participants had trouble understanding the benefit of accurate statistics and information alone. They wanted more information about how these accurate statistics would be used to improve the lives of people in the United States. Participants from the Older White group [FG8 – Older White] had many questions about Benefit 4, specifically regarding the actual benefits that stem from accurate statistics. One participant [FG8 – Older White] said, "The bottom line is: Are you using this to improve the lives of people? [...] For example, homeless population in the country? If that's the case, I'm all for it. You're not telling what they're doing with this information!" One of the Spanish-speaking groups [FG10 – Hispanic] had similar concerns because they have no guarantees that more accurate data will be used to help the country.

Participants echoed questions that they had raised earlier when talking about the frame in terms of outdated data and data accuracy. Participants in five groups [FG4 – Young White; FG7 – Higher Education; FG8 – Older White; FG9 – Low Education; FG12 – Older AA] expressed concerns about outdated or inaccurate information in the database. In the Young White group [FG4 – Young White] two participants thought that data could become outdated and questioned the frequency in which data would be added/updated. In the Low Education group, one participant [FG9 – Low Education] approved of the use of Google data, which contains constantly updated data, to develop the database, motivated by concerns of outdated information. Some participants in the Older African American group [FG12 – Older AA] noted that their personal information would not necessarily be more accurate because it may be old or outdated. One participant [FG7 – Higher Education] noted "The information is going to be as accurate as the one providing it." One participant from the Higher Education group [FG7 – Higher Education] also wondered how the government would ensure that accurate statistics and information were produced from the database. All these participants were thinking about individual data being inaccurate and did not understand that aggregated statistics could be more accurate regardless of individual data.

Some participants were concerned about the data being manipulated by end users or the government being unable to ensure that statistics were more accurate. One participant [FG4

– Young White] felt that there is a risk that data could be “skewed” to provide the “best picture” by the end user. The participants in one of the Low Trust groups [FG2 – Low Trust] felt that the government could not ensure that accurate statistics would be produced. One participant asked, “Is this a fact?”

Examples of information and statistics that participants thought about with this benefit included the following:

- Population count [FG5 – Low Trust; FG8 – Older White; FG10 – Hispanic]
- Unhoused population count [FG5 – Low Trust; FG8 – Older White]
- Demographics [FG10 – Hispanic]
- Crime rates [FG5 – Low Trust]
- Birth rates and gender [FG5 – Low Trust]
- Tracking vulnerable populations [FG5 – Low Trust]

Another positive reaction to Benefit 4 was reported by one participant from a Low Trust group [FG5 – Low Trust]. This participant thought that information between different government sources could be compared to check the accuracy stating, “All the agencies have the information that they use so they can compare their databases and they can make it more efficient.”

Two groups [FG6 – Hispanic; FG9 – Low Education] reacted more positively to Benefit 4 than the other groups. The Spanish-speaking group [FG6 – Hispanic] relayed similar positive statements that they reported when thinking about the frame in general. They specifically thought about the possible benefits for their communities, with one participant [FG6 – Hispanic] mentioning how important it is for the government to be informed whether there are more Hispanic residents in a specific county. The number of Hispanic residents could be used to find out if there is a need for more schools or more teachers. The Low Education group [FG9 – Low Education] thought that having accurate data was good but did not expand on why they felt that way.

Benefit 5: Complete Survey Responses

Participants across five groups [FG4 – Young White; FG6 – Hispanic; FG10 – Hispanic; FG11 – Young AA; FG12 – Older AA] did see Benefit 5 as a benefit and thought it would be worthwhile to have more complete information. One group [FG4 – Young White] clearly understood the impact that missing data would cause. One participant [FG4 – Young White] understood why the government would find it problematic to have missing data. Another participant [FG4 – Young White], explained, “I think this is a benefit. People could avoid providing responses, and then we could fill in the data from other sources.” Participants in one of the Spanish-speaking groups [FG10 – Hispanic] agreed with this benefit, noting that not everyone answers the decennial census, so this database can complement that

information. The participants mentioned that this database can update information about the households, such as if a household member moved out, or is no longer alive, or if there is a newborn in a family. One participant [FG11 – Young AA] saw Benefit 5 positively, explaining that a lot of people do not like filling out surveys, especially if they do not know where the information is going or what the information will be used for. This participant thought that this database could help in situations when there is missing information that people have chosen not to provide.

However, not everyone saw “filling in missing information” as a positive. Some participants across three groups [FG5 – Low Trust; FG7 – Higher Education; FG10 – Hispanic] felt that people may leave information on surveys missing on purpose and had a problem with these details being filled in by other means. Two participants [FG7 – Higher Education] mentioned that some people may leave answers blank if they do not want the government to know certain information and wondered if filling in those responses would result in incorrect assumptions. One participant [FG10 – Hispanic] did not believe Benefit 5 was an actual benefit, because he believed that missing information is due to a respondent’s conscious decision to not provide this information. These sentiments were also established in the cognitive interviews, where two participants thought that missing information was often left off for a reason, and the government should go back to people and ask for it. One participant from a Low Trust group [FG5 – Low Trust] was concerned about consent, as mentioned earlier when discussing the frame overall. This participant stated, “People should consent to the information they want to give to the government.”

Again, participants were not aware that the Census Bureau conducts research outside of the decennial census. Participants from two groups [FG5 – Low Trust; FG10 – Hispanic] were only thinking about responses to the decennial census when reviewing Benefit 5. For the Spanish-speaking group [FG10 – Hispanic], the participants agreed with Benefit 5, noting that not everyone answers the decennial census, so this can complement that information. One participant from the Low Trust group [FG5 – Low Trust] stated, “[Benefit 5] is talking about census survey responses.”

Some participants raised questions around Benefit 5, such as data accuracy, updated data, and logistics. In the Low Education group [FG9 – Low Education] one participant shared some uncertainty as to how missing responses could be fill in. Two participants in the Older White group [FG8 – Older White] were doubtful after reviewing Benefit 5. One of the participants wanted to know if the government will cross check the information and how the government would fill in missing responses. This participant stated, “If there is an issue with my information, will they check with me about which is correct?” Other participants also [FG9 – Low Education] thought filling in missing responses could only be done if the database has the most up-to-date information.

4.4 Concerns about the Frame

Participants raised concerns throughout the focus group discussions. We felt it was best to summarize the concerns here rather than in other sections. There is a lot of overlap between the types of questions participants raised and the concerns they had, but some new ideas emerged as well. **Table 4.6** summarizes the main concerns and the number of focus groups in which the concern was raised.

Table 4.6 Most Common Concerns Raised by Focus Groups

Concern Theme	Number of Focus Groups
Reason/purpose of the database	12
Data accuracy	9
Data security	9
Benefits are unclear	7
Consent to data sharing	7
Dislike private company involvement	7
Unclear how the database will be constructed	4
Who can access the data?	4
Cost of creating the database	4
Lack of control	3

The issues most commonly raised by participants when discussing their questions and concerns involved wanting more details about the reason or purpose for the database, specifically how the data were going to be used. When discussing their concerns about the database, participants across many of the groups brought up additional concerns such as the data will be used for negative purposes, including raising taxes, identifying law breakers or enforcing program rules or discriminating against marginalized groups. One participant [FG10 – Hispanic] stated repeatedly that she thought the database would be used against regular citizens to identify ways to increase taxes. Another participant [FG5 – Low Trust] wondered if police departments would have access to the database, stating “If the agencies are in cahoots, does this make it more easily accessible for the police to look at your data without a warrant? How will it affect privacy?” Participants from another Low Trust group [FG2 – Low Trust] had similar concerns about law enforcement accessing the database and using the database to identify people who had not paid their taxes. Participants in this group [FG2 – Low Trust] were concerned that the database would be used to find people who do not follow government rules.

Participants in a Low Trust group [FG1 – Low Trust] had concerns about whether the database would be used to discriminate against people, with one participant elaborating “If you have all the power, we can use the power for good or for evil. If you’re rich you’re good. If you’re not, you may be discriminated against.” One participant from another group

[FG12 – Older AA] was also worried that the database may be used to “pick on” specific groups of people by potentially collecting information from some groups, such as those who receive SNAP or WIC benefits, while not collecting information from other groups like lawyers, doctors, and teachers. This participant was concerned about bias or differential treatment of groups.

Two participants in the Low Education group [FG9 – Low Education] worried about how the information in the database would be used against them. One participant shared, “If the programs are working okay, then leave them alone. Don’t tie all the stuff together. If they tie all the stuff together, they will pull it back. They will find that you missed a payment, or you don’t qualify for a program.” One participant shared, “Insurance uses actuarial tables to determine rates. Medicare is using geographical information to determine a premium. It’s a negative because it’s cold and not putting a face on it. Using numbers or statistics to put a price on it. I wonder if that’s a use of this database. Should a park be in my area? Or two more bus stops. This person is young enough to walk they don’t need a bus.” Another participant in the Low Education group was also concerned that the database may be implemented as a “big brother” system explaining, “Would they want to know if we are hiding people? If people are registered. Not US citizens.”

The participants were concerned about the security of the database and the privacy that would be maintained with the database. Participants from several groups were concerned about hacking or data breaches [FG4 – Young White; FG7 – Higher Education; FG12 – Older AA; FG1 – Low Trust; FG2 – Low Trust; FG3 – High Trust]. For example, one participant [FG7 – Higher Education] asked, “How do you safeguard this? How secure is this? Will this make us more vulnerable?” The Older African American group [FG12 – Older AA] was specifically worried about identity theft, with one participant stating, “I just want to make sure my stuff doesn’t fall into the hands of someone who shouldn’t have my information...like identity theft.” Some of the groups [FG1 – Low Trust, FG2 – Low Trust] had doubts about the government being able to properly secure the database from hackers. Other participants were not as worried about the government being unable to keep the data safe but instead concerned that having all these data in one place would be an attractive target for hackers who could misuse the information.

In addition to data security, participants were worried about data accuracy, as reported previously. These participants were concerned about the impacts of inaccurate data and how difficult it might be to identify data errors. One participant [FG4 – Young White] stated, “How is this information being entered into the system? I worry about data error. How much is automated, how much is imputed by humans? And how much of the data is quality checked? I am not opposed to the idea, but I just don’t have enough info to know whether it would work.” Some participants [FG12 – Older AA] were especially concerned about the accuracy of their own data in the database, which is related to a topic that will be discussed

further—how the data will be used. Some of these participants wanted to be able to review their data themselves to confirm it was accurate.

Even after reviewing the five benefit statements, participants were left with many questions about any concrete benefits of the database, especially individual benefits. Participants wanted to know more about the details of how the database would be used to improve people's lives. From the Young White group [FG4 – Young White], two participants expressed a desire to learn more. One participant felt that he understood the “big picture” but would like to know more about the overall program and how it would operate. The other participant felt that this shows the Census Bureau wants to do the best job possible but would like examples of how this will help people. In another group [FG8 – Older White], one participant was unclear how statistics would be used to implement concrete benefits for people, stating “We already have so many statistics out there that show that rural populations don't have access to health care. But we don't see any improvement to that. In fact, hospitals are closing and pulling out. We see so many articles and yet – nothing is done. You can have all the statistics in the world, but if it's not improving anyone's quality of life.”

Participants in two groups [FG4 - Young White; FG11 – Young AA] wanted more details about individual benefits rather than community benefits. One participant [FG4 – Young White] felt the description was vague and preferred to have concrete examples or case studies to explain the benefits to individuals. Another participant [FG11 – Young AA] shared a general concern about whether they would personally benefit from the database. Participants in one of the Low Trust groups [FG1 – Low Trust] still felt confused about community benefits as well.

The process for opting in or consenting to inclusion in the database continued to be a concern throughout the group discussions. Participants wanted to be explicitly informed about their data's inclusion in the database and wanted to be able to consent to what data was shared. One participant [FG5 – Low Trust] asked, “Can it be optional? Can we opt out? Can we choose some information but keep other stuff private?” Another participant in a different group [FG9 – Low Education] thought that a “Terms of Agreement” should be shared with people given a chance to opt out of this database, like what is done within Google products. Another participant [FG8 – Older White] thought that the database was too similar to what private companies, such as Facebook, were doing, stating “The government is acting like Facebook, and I don't want the government to do that. Facebook wants to sell my stuff.” This participant noted that citizens would like to have as much control as possible over their information.

Related to this point about consent, participants in multiple groups [FG10 – Hispanic; FG9 – Low Education; FG11 – Young AA] thought that the way the database is communicated to the public would be very important. One participant [FG10 – Hispanic] expressed concern

over how people would be informed of the database, asking, “Will there be some sort of rollout in the mail or an email asking us to consent to it or will it just happen?” This participant, along with another participant [FG10 – Hispanic] explained that they felt it would be important for people to have a say in whether their information is accessed and shared, citing examples of situations in which their phone number had been shared without their consent. Participants in the Low Education group all wanted to get more information about this database before supporting it. Information could be provided through a sheet of paper on what the Census Bureau does, detailing the program, how the database is created, and its frequency of update. Similarly, in the Young African American group, one participant wanted to know how information about the plan would be communicated to people. This participant felt that people should receive detailed information about the plan and its purpose in advance and that this might “Get people more motivated to give good information.”

As discussed earlier in **Section 4.2**, participants were against the idea of linking private company data with government data in one database. Specifically, participants had concerns about whether private companies would be able to access the entire database and whether these companies may profit from these data. Participants preferred sharing data between government agencies rather than sharing data with private companies. Some participants in one group [FG10 – Hispanic] thought that the government should not have access to all information about them and should not use private company data to access more data, such as health or personal finances. Participants in the Older African American group [FG12 – Older AA] worried about data being shared with their employers. Participants from two groups [FG12 – Older AA; FG10 – Hispanic] wondered what private companies may receive in return for cooperating in data sharing. They wondered how expensive it would be for the government to access data from private companies and whether companies would in return get access to the entire database. Related to the concern about the cost of data from private companies, some participants raised overall concerns about how much the database would cost. One participant [FG8 – Older White] asked what the cost of the database would be and how many extra people would have to be hired to make this happen.

Participants had concerns about the logistics of how the database would be constructed. In addition to the question mentioned earlier in **Section 4.2** about how the data would be shared between agencies, participants had questions about how the database would be developed and maintained. Participants from one group [FG12 – Older AA] had several concerns around this topic. One participant [FG12 – Older AA] wanted to know more about the people entering information into the system and specifically, how much experience they have. This participant felt that these individuals should have background checks run on them. Another participant [FG12 – Older AA] wanted to know whether the information that

they collect from surveys would be shredded or held on to once the information has been combined with the other data sources.

In addition to concerns about nefarious individuals accessing the database, participants questioned who would be provided legitimate access to the database. One participant [FG4 – Young White] asked, “Who owns the data? Do I have access to this information? Does the government own the data and how will they use it?” Another participant [FG8 – Older White] wondered who the gatekeepers will be and who will have access to the information once it is compiled. Two participants from another group [FG9 – Low Education] wanted to know who would have access to this database, especially regarding data about themselves. One participant [FG9 – Low Education] shared that it would be helpful to use the information in the database to apply for a passport.

Several participants from the Older African American group [FG12 – Older AA] expressed concerns about not knowing who would have access to the database and how they would obtain access. One of these participants [FG12 – Older AA] was curious how access would be regulated. Another participant [FG12 – Older AA] asked, “Who has access to it? Are there protocols in terms of who has access to it and are people keeping track of it?”

One final concern that came up across a few groups was the idea that individuals did not have any control over whether the database happened or not. This sentiment was presented in **Section 4.1** when discussing data collection in general and came up again at the end of the group discussions, primarily in the Low Trust groups [FG1 – Low Trust, FG5 – Low Trust]. One participant [FG5 – Low Trust] stated, “But it doesn’t matter cause [the government] will do what they want to do anyways. They are going to do it anyway.” This idea of lack of control also came up in the Low Education group [FG9 – Low Education] where one participant shared that they really were not concerned because this is something they do not have control over even though they do think this is an invasion of privacy.

5. Summary and Conclusions

In reviewing the focus group findings, several “themes” became evident. The following are overall findings from review of the focus group discussions:

1. Consistently, the low trust groups demonstrated the strongest opposition to the frame. They were suspicious of anything that the government was involved with and advocated for smaller government. Providing additional information about the frame or the potential benefits were met with cynicism and, at times, anger. The high trust groups were more open to the idea but had many questions that were left unanswered.
2. Participants were first provided with a general description of the frame, later followed by a more detailed description. In general, participants had a lot of questions after hearing both descriptions. Several of them felt like the Census Bureau is “holding back” and should provide a more detailed and transparent description of what the frame would include, where the data are coming from, why the frame is needed, how the data will be used, and how the frame will be protected.
3. Many of the participants thought the Census Bureau already has an established central database. The participants questioned why there would be a need to build a database when government agencies already work together and share information. Some participants thought it was possible that the Census Bureau did not have all the information they needed so that is why they are looking to gather information and involve private companies. However, this raised questions among some participants as to what types of data private companies could provide.
4. Some participants thought that medical or mental health records might be included in this database, although one participant explained that this wouldn’t be possible due to HIPAA. In general, participants conflated the topics of health information and government data. They did not recognize that health data are excepted from data sharing arrangements.
5. Some participants questioned whether personally identifiable information would be included in the database. In several cases, participants were unfamiliar with the term “statistics” and did not seem to have a good understanding of the type of data that would be included in the database, such as demographic information. Rather, some participants thought of all types of data as potentially being gathered. For example, government tax records, DMV records, health records, cell phone data, social media activity, etc.

6. When thinking about the Census Bureau's motivation for creating the frame, several participants raised the topic of profits or monetization of the frame. They believed that the Census would seek to sell the data or make money from this product.
7. Participants tended to overestimate rates of data sharing between private companies and the government. Their discussions of data privacy assumed that the government had access to people's social media data or purchase history from companies such as Google, Meta, and Amazon.
8. Overall, participants generally did not like the idea of gathering data from private companies to be included in the frame. Some felt it was "government overreach" and others questioned the quality of data from private companies. However, a few participants felt companies like Google and Amazon maintained up-to-date accurate data.
9. The participants only thought of a few individual benefits to building the frame but did recognize several potential community benefits. Those five perceived benefits are as follows:
 - a. Benefit 1 (fewer surveys) was not found to be a compelling benefit for most participants, with many seeing it as negative. Participants explained that they were fine with completing surveys and felt this would be the best way to maintain the most accurate information.
 - b. Benefit 2 (better use of taxpayer money) was seen by some participants as a perceived benefit, with participants explaining that the database could positively impact community services such as parks, schools, day care centers, health services, and general infrastructure.
 - c. Benefit 3 (deliver services more efficiently) was perceived as one of the most concrete benefits for participants.
 - d. Benefit 4 (more accurate statistics) was not as clear of a benefit for many participants. Participants had trouble understanding the benefit of accurate statistics and information alone. They wanted more information about how these accurate statistics would be used to improve peoples' lives.
 - e. Benefit 5 (complete survey responses) was viewed as a benefit, and participants thought it would be worthwhile to have more complete information.
10. Several participants were generally concerned about a "loss of information" through hacking or other malicious intent. Privacy protections and potential data breaches were brought up within several of the focus groups.

11. Some participants raised concerns about data quality. If information was compiled from other agencies, participants were not sure how accurate or up-to-date the information would be.
12. Several of the participants were not aware that the Census Bureau conducts research outside of the decennial census. This added to the confusion of some participants as they thought of the data collected during the decennial census and could not envision what data would be included in the frame. However, some participants in the Spanish-speaking group saw this as a benefit as they acknowledge that Latinx participation in the decennial census is low. The data compiled in this new database could help to “complete” the information.
13. Participants expressed preferences about being asked to provide consent for their data being included in the frame. The concept of whether they can opt out of the database was raised frequently. They also preferred to receive mail or communications campaigns announcing the project and would like to be able to review / correct their frame data.
14. Overall, participants were open to the Census Bureau heading up this effort when considering alternative agencies, such as the IRS. Participants generally felt that this would naturally fall on the Census Bureau as they are the agency that collects information about the U.S. population.

These overall findings should be considered when planning for the next stage in the development of communications about the demographic frame. Addressing these concerns and questions will help to reduce the public’s concerns and add more transparency to the effort.

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Appendix A: RoPOAR SP3 Focus Group Moderator's Guide – Remote

Date: ____/____/____

Start time: ____ AM / PM

Moderators: _____

PID Number: _____

Mode: Virtual ____

MODERATOR: THIS IS A GUIDE TO HELP YOU LEAD THE DISCUSSION. YOU CAN MODIFY AND ADAPT THESE QUESTIONS TO MEET SITUATIONAL NEEDS DURING EACH SESSION.

SECTION I: INTRODUCTION (10 minutes)

Welcome! Thank you for talking with us today. My name is [MODERATOR NAME] and I'm here with my colleague, [NOTETAKER NAME]. I will be guiding our discussion today. We will discuss a number of topics related to government records and information that the government has about people in the country. [NOTETAKER NAME] will take notes so we don't miss anything important.

We work for RTI International and are working with the Census Bureau's Center for Behavioral Science Methods on this effort. [We have a couple of other people from Census Bureau observing our conversation today and also helping us make sure we don't miss anything.] We'll be recording our session so we can make sure to get all your feedback.

Please mute the call if you are not talking so we can be sure to hear everyone. We want everyone to have the chance to share their opinion, so I may call on you if we haven't heard from you on a topic.

Let's first take a look at the consent form. [Moderator: share the consent form on screen]

Please take a moment to read through the consent form.

Does anyone have any questions about that before we get started?

We really appreciate that you are taking this time out of your day to share your thoughts with all of us. Before we begin, we have a few ground rules for our discussion:

RULES

- **First, I will be asking a lot of questions.** There are no right or wrong answers to my questions; we just want your honest opinions. We don't need to have everyone agree. In fact, if you have a view different from others it is especially important for us to hear it because you may be the only person who is representing a different point of view here today.
- **Be respectful of other people's comments.** It is fine to disagree with each other's comments, but let's do so politely. We are interested in listening to everybody's opinion in a respectful manner.

- **Please keep information confidential.** This means that we want everyone to respect opinions shared here and not share them with others.
- **Only one person speaks at a time and we'd like everyone to get a turn.** Please do not speak while somebody else is talking because it's hard to understand when too many people talk at once. Please speak up and let us know what you are thinking. If you are the type of person who always participates, please also give others a chance to talk. Since we are online, I may call on folks to make sure we get a chance to hear from everyone.
- Due to **limited time**, I must move the discussion along and may sometimes have to interrupt in order to do so. Please do not be offended. If you have anything else that you'd like to share with us that you did not have time to say, you will have an opportunity to follow up via email.
- We are **recording** the session and also have a notetaker, so we don't miss anything that is said. We will only use first names during this discussion, and we won't ask questions that would identify you in any way. Only researchers who are working on the study will have access to the recording.

Does anyone have any questions before we get started? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS AT THIS POINT]

ICEBREAKER

The first thing I want to do is get to know each of you a little better. Let's go around and have each one of you tell us briefly:

- Your first name and one thing you really like about where you live.

I'll go first. My name is... [BE BRIEF AND BUILD RAPPORT BY SHARING EXPERIENCE SIMILAR TO THEIRS] [START THE RECORDING]

SECTION II: PROBES (75 minutes)

Thank you for telling us a little more about you. Let's start by discussing a few topics.

A1. General Government Data Collection – General (~15 minutes)

1. What comes to mind when you think about data?
 - a. Were you thinking about government data or data from other sources?
2. How do companies and government get data about you?
 - a. What kinds of data are we talking about?
 - b. Is this data that you provide to them, or data that they get from other sources? What types of sources?
3. How much control do you feel you have over data being collected about you?
 - a. Do you have more control over government data collection or data from private companies? Tell me more about this.
 - b. Tell me about the ways you can control your data?
4. What types of data does the government have about you?

5. What are some ways that you benefit from the government having data about you and your community?
6. What are the risks to the government having data about you?
7. Do you trust the government to keep your data secure? Why or why not?
 - a. Do you trust the government to use your data in a way that you think is appropriate? Why or why not?
8. Do you have any concerns about how the government uses the data that it collects about you or are you not concerned?
 - a. Why is that?

A2. Describing/Understanding the Frame (~20 minutes)

The Census Bureau plans to build a new database about people that combines information from other government agencies, government surveys you may have answered in the past, and private companies. The database would only be used to produce statistics.

1. What do you think about this plan?
2. How would you describe this effort to someone who was learning about it for the first time?
3. What agencies do you think the Census Bureau might get data from? What types of data do those agencies have?
4. Do you think that people will be in favor of this, or would they be opposed to it, or might they not have an opinion?
 - a. Why is that?
5. What questions do you have about this? What types of things do you want to know about this to help you understand it better?
6. What are the possible benefits of having the Census Bureau create this database?
 - a. [IF NEEDED]: For example, would there be any personal benefits to you? Would there be benefits to others? How about ways this could benefit the community?
 - b. Why would the Census Bureau be interested in doing this?
7. Does this bring up any concerns? If so, what kinds of concerns do you have?
[MODERATOR: REVIEW FOR MENTIONS OF PRIVACY]
8. Would something like this affect you personally? How does this affect your opinions about it?
 - a. Are there some people that it might affect more than others?

9. Do you think that this is something that is easy to understand or difficult to understand? Why is that?

I'm going to give you some more information about this database. [MODERATOR: Share a screen that states this information] This database would link together information about individuals. Some examples are age, sex, race, ethnicity, education, income. The data would come from sources such as the Social Security Administration, IRS, and government programs such as SNAP and WIC.

1. How do you feel about this plan after learning this? Do you feel the same or differently after hearing this information?
2. What if the database used data from private companies?
 - a. Do you think the government already has this data, or would they be collecting more data than they had before?
3. [IF THE GROUP HAS SHOWN TO BE FAVORABLE TO THIS DATA COLLECTION IN THE QUANTITATIVE SURVEY] Are there examples of how you have benefitted from the data that the government has about you?
 - a. What about an example of how your community has benefitted from this?

A3. Concerns about the Frame (~15 minutes)

We are interested in knowing if anyone has concerns about Census' plans to create this database.

1. Is there anything that you are concerned about?
2. Are there questions that you would want answers to before you supported this plan?
3. Is there any additional information you would want to learn about this plan?

As we have discussed the Census Bureau is leading this effort to develop this database.

1. Is that important to you to know this is an effort led by the Census Bureau?
2. How does that make a difference, compared to if another agency were to do this (such as the IRS or the Social Security Administration)?

SECTION III: CONCLUSION (5 minutes)

1. Is there anything else you'd like to tell us that you haven't had a chance to mention yet?
 - a. Anyone else?

Before we end the group, I want to remind you that the Census Bureau is committed to keeping your personal information confidential. Census Bureau employees are sworn for life to protect your confidentiality. Any Census Bureau employee who violates Title 13 is subject to a fine up to \$250,000, a prison sentence up to five years, or both. Does anyone have any questions?

Appendix B: RoPOAR SP3 Focus Group Moderator's Guide – In-Person

Date: ____/____/____

Start time: ____ AM / PM

Moderators: _____

PID Number: _____

Group Location: RTP__ Chicago__ Berkeley __ DC__

Mode: In-person (audio and video)

***MODERATOR: THIS IS A GUIDE TO HELP YOU LEAD THE DISCUSSION. YOU CAN
MODIFY AND ADAPT THESE QUESTIONS TO MEET SITUATIONAL NEEDS DURING
EACH SESSION.***

SECTION I: INTRODUCTION (10 minutes)

Welcome! Thank you for talking with us today. My name is [MODERATOR NAME] and I'm here with my colleague, [NOTETAKER NAME]. I will be guiding our discussion today. We will discuss a number of topics related to government records and information that the government has about people in the country. [NOTETAKER NAME] will take notes so we don't miss anything important.

We work for RTI International and are working with the Census Bureau's Center for Behavioral Science Methods on this effort.

[IF OBSERVERS: We have a couple of other people from Census Bureau observing our conversation today and also helping us make sure we don't miss anything.]

We'll be recording our session so we can make sure to get all your feedback.

Let's first take a look at the consent form. [DISTRIBUTE CONSENT FORM]

Please take a moment to read through the consent form. Does anyone have any questions about that before we get started?

We really appreciate that you are taking this time out of your day to share your thoughts with all of us. Before we begin, we have a few ground rules for our discussion:

RULES

- **First, I will be asking a lot of questions.** There are no right or wrong answers to my questions; we just want your honest opinions. We don't need to have everyone agree. In fact, if you have a view different from others it is especially important for us to hear it because you may be the only person who is representing a different point of view here today.

- **Be respectful of other people's comments.** It is fine to disagree with each other's comments, but let's do so politely. We are interested in listening to everybody's opinion in a respectful manner.
- **Please keep information confidential.** This means that we want everyone to respect opinions shared here and not share them with others.
- **Only one person speaks at a time, and we'd like everyone to get a turn.** Please do not speak while somebody else is talking because it's hard to understand when too many people talk at once. Please speak up and let us know what you are thinking. If you are the type of person who always participates, please also give others a chance to talk.
- Due to **limited time**, I must move the discussion along and may sometimes have to interrupt in order to do so. Please do not be offended. If you have anything else that you'd like to share with us that you did not have time to say, please send your feedback to the e-mail specified in the instructions you received for this focus group.
- We are **recording** the session and also have a notetaker, so we don't miss anything that is said. We will only use first names during this discussion, and we won't ask questions that would identify you in any way. Only researchers who are working on the study will have access to the recording.

Does anyone have any questions before we get started? [ANSWER ANY QUESTIONS AT THIS POINT]

ICEBREAKER

The first thing I want to do is get to know each of you a little better. Let's go around (the room) and have each one of you tell us briefly:

- Your first name and one thing you really like about where you live.

I'll go first. My name is... [BE BRIEF AND BUILD RAPPORT BY SHARING EXPERIENCE SIMILAR TO THEIRS]

[START THE RECORDING]

SECTION II: PROBES (75 minutes)

Thank you for telling us a little more about you. Let's start by discussing data.

A1. General Government Data Collection – General (~15 minutes)

What comes to mind when you think about data?

- Were you thinking about government data or data from other sources?

How do companies and government get data about you?

- What kinds of data are we talking about?

d. Is this data that you provide to them, or data that they get from other sources?

i. What types of sources?

How much control do you feel you have over data being collected about you?

e. Do you have more control over government data collection or data from private companies? Tell me more about your answer here.

What are some ways that you benefit from the government having data about you and your community?

A2. Describing/Understanding the Frame (~20 minutes)

The Census Bureau plans to build a new database about people that combines information from other government agencies, government surveys you may have answered in the past, and private companies. The database would only be used to produce statistics.

What do you think about this?

What agencies do you think the Census Bureau might get data from? What types of data do those agencies have?

What questions do you have about this?

a. What types of things do you want to know about this to help you understand it better?

What are the possible benefits in having the Census Bureau create this database?

[IF NEEDED]: For example, would there be any personal benefits to you? How about ways this could benefit the community?

Why would the Census Bureau be interested in doing this?

Does this bring up any concerns? If so, what kinds of concerns do you have? [MODERATOR: REVIEW FOR MENTIONS OF PRIVACY]

Do you think that this is something that is easy to understand or difficult to understand? Why is that?

I'm going to give you some more information about this database. This database would link together information about individuals. Some examples are age, sex, race, ethnicity, education, income. The data would come from sources such as the Social Security Administration, IRS, and government programs such as SNAP and WIC.

What are your reactions to this? Do you feel the same or differently?

What if the database linked to your address using data from private companies? Would you feel differently?

A3. Benefits of the Frame (~25 minutes)

Developing this database could help the Census bureau do the work that they do. It can also help people throughout the country and the communities that they live in. Let's discuss this a little more. I want to describe some benefits of this database to people and their communities. Please tell me what you think about each one.

[IN PERSON GROUP: PROVIDE HANDOUT THAT LISTS EACH OF THESE 5 BENEFITS]

- 1. Developing this database could mean that you are asked to fill out surveys less often because your information is already available.**
 - a. What are your initial thoughts when you hear this?
 - b. Do you find this to be a negative or positive feature and why?
 - i. (If needed): Do you feel the benefits of sharing your information outweigh the risks?
- 2. Developing this database could help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money.**
 - a. When you hear "government agencies" – What are you thinking about?
 - i. (If needed): Does any specific government agency come to mind?
 - b. In what ways do you think the database could help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money?
- 3. Developing this database could help your local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently.**
 - a. What kinds of services and benefits do you think this refers to?
 - b. How do you think this database would help local governments provide these services/benefits?
- 4. Developing this database would mean that information and statistics about the country are more accurate.**
 - a. What do you think this statement means in your own words?
 - b. What comes to mind when you hear "...information and statistics about the country?"
 - i. (If needed): Can you provide examples of 'information and statistics about the country' as used in this statement?
- 5. Developing this database would help complete survey responses when information is missing.**
 - a. How do you think this database could help, "...complete survey responses when information is missing?"
 - b. Why do you think this would be beneficial?

A4. Concerns about the Frame (~15 minutes)

We are interested in knowing if anyone has concerns about Census' plans to create this database.

Is there anything that you are concerned about?

Are there questions that you would want answers to before you supported this plan?

Is there any additional information you would want added to the explanation of this plan?

As we have discussed the Census Bureau is leading this effort to develop this database.

Is it important to you to know this is an effort led by the Census Bureau?

How does that make a difference, compared to if another agency were to do this (such as the IRS or the Social Security Administration)?

SECTION III: CONCLUSION (5 minutes)

Is there anything else you'd like to tell us that you haven't had a chance to mention yet?

b. Anyone else?

Before we end the group, I want to remind you that the Census Bureau is committed to keeping your personal information confidential. Census Bureau employees are sworn for life to protect your confidentiality. Any Census Bureau employee who violates Title 13 is subject to a fine up to \$250,000, a prison sentence up to five years, or both. Does anyone have any questions?

Thank you very much for your time! The feedback that you shared was very helpful.

[DISTRIBUTE INCENTIVE AND INCENTIVE RECEIPT TO SIGN]

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Appendix C: In-Person Participant Screening Instrument

INTRO.

Please complete this short screening survey to determine your eligibility to participate in an in-person focus group that will last about 90 minutes.

Q1. What is your age? [numeric text box entry]

Q2. What sex were you assigned at birth, on your original birth certificate?

1. Male
2. Female

Q3. Do you currently describe yourself as male, female or transgender?

1. Male
2. Female
3. Transgender
4. Something else - please specify: [open end text box]

Q4. What is your race? Please select all that apply.

1. White
2. Black or African American
3. American Indian or Alaska Native
4. Asian
5. Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander
6. Some other race – Specify [OPEN FIELD]

Q5. Are you of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin?

1. Yes
2. No [IF Q5=1] – Q5a. Which language do you tend to speak at home?
 1. English
 2. Spanish
 3. Both equally
 4. Other – Specify [OPEN FIELD]

Q6. How concerned are you, if at all, about how companies use the data they collect about you?

1. Extremely concerned
2. Moderately concerned
3. A little concerned
4. Not at all concerned

Q7. How concerned are you, if at all, about how the government is using the data it collects about you?

1. Extremely concerned
2. Moderately concerned
3. A little concerned
4. Not at all concerned

Q8. Personally, how much trust do you have in federal statistics in the United States?

Would you say that you tend to trust federal statistics, or you tend not to trust them?

1. Tend to trust federal statistics
2. Tend not to trust federal statistics

Q9. How confident are you in each of these institutions in American society?					
Institutions	Extremely confident	Very confident	Somewhat confident	A little confident	Not at all Confident
1. Newspapers	()	()	()	()	()
2. The military	()	()	()	()	()
3. The U.S. Census Bureau	()	()	()	()	()
4. The U.S. Congress	()	()	()	()	()
5. Universities	()	()	()	()	()

[INTERNAL USE: If Q5 =1 or 2 and Q6 =1 or 2 and Q7=2 and Q8=a little/not at all (any): then R is classified as more concerned. If Q5 =3 or 4 and Q6 =3 or 4 and Q7=1 and Q8 does not equal little/not at all (any): then R is classified as less concerned. Any other combinations will be considered of mixed concern.]

Q10. Please provide the city and state in which you live:

[OPEN] City

[OPEN] State

Q11. Please provide the following contact information in case you are selected for the focus group:

Q11a. First name: [OPEN FIELD]

Q11b. Email address: [OPEN FIELD]

Q11c. Telephone number: [OPEN FIELD]

Q12. Would you be willing to participate in a 90 minute in-person focus group in [LOCATION] at a day/time to be determine in the month of [MONTH]?

YES

NO

Q13. Can we have your permission to send text messages? This will be used to communicate about the focus group.

YES

NO

THANK YOU.

Thank you. We will review your responses and reach out to you if you are selected for the in-person focus group. Please press [SUBMIT] to submit your responses.

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Appendix D: Virtual Focus Group Consent Form



Consent Form

Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records – Focus Group

The Census Bureau routinely conducts research and collects information from people across the United States to gather information about upcoming initiatives.

I consent to take part in a focus group regarding your opinions on government records. In order to have a complete record of all comments, the focus group discussion will be audio-recorded. The Census Bureau plans to use the recordings to assist in the analysis of the information gathered during the group discussions. Staff directly involved in the project will have access to the recordings. Participation is voluntary and answers will remain strictly confidential. You may withdraw from the discussion at any time. Your participation and any comments you make will be kept confidential. Comments from all participants will be combined in a summary report that will not identify any individual. The focus group discussion is expected to take about 90 minutes. You will receive \$75 as a token of appreciation for your participation.

This study is being conducted under the authority of Title 13 USC 8(b) and Title 29 USC 3141. The OMB control number for this study is 0607-0978; it expires 12/31/2023. Without this number, we could not collect your information. Federal law requires the protection of your privacy (Title 5 U.S. Code, Section 552a). Furnishing this information is voluntary; however, failure to do so will limit the Census Bureau's ability to gather information used in the development of survey instruments, and other communication materials in order to produce materials that are clear and easy for people to understand. Personally Identifiable Information collected includes name, telephone/cellular phone number, DOB or age, email address, race, or ethnicity. The information provided to us may be shared with other Census Bureau staff, contractors and those who have a need to know for work-related purposes and as identified in the Privacy Act System of Records Notice COMMERCE/Census-3 Special Censuses, Surveys, and Other Studies. If you have comments or questions about this study, please email adrm.pra@census.gov.

I have agreed to participate in this Census Bureau focus group research study, and I give permission for my recording to be used for the purposes stated above.

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Appendix E: In-Person Focus Group Consent Form



Consent Form

Research on Public Opinion of Administrative Records – Focus Group

The Census Bureau routinely conducts research and collects information from people across the United States to gather information about upcoming initiatives.

I consent to take part in a focus group regarding your opinions on government records. In order to have a complete record of all comments, the focus group discussion will be audio-recorded. The Census Bureau plans to use the recordings to assist in the analysis of the information gathered during the group discussions. Staff directly involved in the project will have access to the recordings. Participation is voluntary and answers will remain strictly confidential. You may withdraw from the discussion at any time. Your participation and any comments you make will be kept confidential. Comments from all participants will be combined in a summary report that will not identify any individual. The focus group discussion is expected to take about 90 minutes. You will receive \$90 as a token of appreciation for your participation.

This study is being conducted under the authority of Title 13 USC 8(b) and Title 29 USC 3141. The OMB control number for this study is 0607-0725; it expires 12/31/2025. Without this number, we could not collect your information. Federal law requires the protection of your privacy (Title 5 U.S. Code, Section 552a). Furnishing this information is voluntary; however, failure to do so will limit the Census Bureau's ability to gather information used in the development of survey instruments, and other communication materials in order to produce materials that are clear and easy for people to understand. Personally Identifiable Information collected includes name, telephone/cellular phone number, DOB or age, email address, race, or ethnicity. The information provided to us may be shared with other Census Bureau staff, contractors and those who have a need to know for work-related purposes and as identified in the Privacy Act System of Records Notice COMMERCE/Census-3 Special Censuses, Surveys, and Other Studies. If you have comments or questions about this study, please email adrm.pra@census.gov.

I have agreed to participate in this Census Bureau focus group research study, and I give permission for my recording to be used for the purposes stated above.

Participant's Signature

Researcher's Signature

Participant's Printed Name

Researcher's Printed Name

Date

Date

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Appendix F: In-Person Recruitment Advertisements

Facebook / Craigslist Online ad

Focus Group Research Opportunity for Qualified Participants

The U.S. Census Bureau is looking for individuals ages 18 and older to participate in a focus group. Participants will be asked to provide input on questions about your opinions on government records. We will be conducting in-person focus groups in both English and Spanish. Each focus group is expected to take about 90 minutes. All responses will be kept confidential. Eligible participants who participate in the group discussion will receive **\$90**.

To see if you are eligible for the study, please complete a short questionnaire at:

[SCREENER HYPERLINK]

Email / Other Social Media Announcement

Subject: Participants needed for an in-person focus group in [city, state] - \$90

The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting a focus group with people aged 18 years and older, in the [city, state] area. Participants will be asked to provide input on questions about your opinions on government records. We will be conducting in-person focus groups in both English and Spanish.

Focus group discussions are expected to last about 90 minutes and will take place at [a convenient location / XX location] in [city, state]. **We will provide \$90 to each person who participates in the in-person focus group discussion.**

If you are interested, please click on the link below to answer questions to see if you qualify. You can also call us at 1-800-334-8571 extension XXXXX. Please feel free to pass this request along to other people that you may know in the [city, state] area. Only one person per household may qualify.
[SCREENER HYPERLINK](#)

Recruiting Focus Group Participants

**** \$90 for participation in a 90 minute in-person focus group ****

The U.S. Census Bureau is conducting a focus group with people aged 18 years and older, in the [city, state] area. We will be conducting in-person focus groups in both English and Spanish.

Participants will be asked to provide input on questions about your opinions on government records. All responses are kept confidential.

The focus group discussion will last about 90 minutes and take place at [a convenient location / XX location] in [city, state].



We will provide \$90 to each person who participates in the focus group discussion. Please go to: [ONLINE SCREENER URL] or call us at 1-800-XXX-XXXX to see if you qualify. [QR CODE] You may also scan the QR code to the right.

And feel free to pass this request along to other people that you may know in the [city, state] area who might qualify.

Appendix G: Potential Frame Benefits Handout

Five Potential Frame Benefits

1. Developing this database could mean that you are asked to fill out surveys less often because your information is already available.
2. Developing this database could help government agencies make better use of taxpayer money.
3. Developing this database could help your local government deliver services and benefits more efficiently.
4. Developing this database would mean that information and statistics about the country are more accurate.
5. Developing this database would help complete survey responses when information is missing.

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Appendix H: Confirmation Email and Reminder Templates

VIRTUAL FOCUS GROUP CONFIRMATION EMAIL

Subject: U.S. Census Bureau Focus Group: Confirmed

Dear [**PARTICIPANT'S NAME**]:

Thank you for agreeing to participate in a virtual focus group for the U.S. Census Bureau.

You are scheduled to participate in the focus group scheduled for [**DAY**], [**DATE**], from [**START TIME**] to [**END TIME**] [**PARTICIPANT TIMEZONE**]. If you are no longer available on this date and time, please contact Carlye Gates Arcas at carlye.g.arcas@census.gov.

Please use the Microsoft Teams meeting link below to join the focus group 15 minutes before the start time. You may be prompted to download Microsoft Teams in order to join the meeting.

Please note that you will be required to have your video turned on for the duration of the focus group.

Microsoft Teams meeting

Join on your computer

[Click here to join the meeting](#)

Meeting ID: 251 513 515 612

Passcode: bSavo8

*If you have any technical difficulties with joining the Teams meeting, please call Tim Flanigan at 919-485-7743.

As a token of appreciation, you will receive a \$75 electronic gift card for participating. This gift card will be sent to your email address approximately 2-3 weeks after the focus group.

I have also included a copy of the consent form. This document covers your rights as a participant and what to expect during the group discussion. The moderator will go over this form prior to the discussion.

Thank you for your participation!

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]

VIRTUAL FOCUS GROUP REMINDER EMAIL

Subject: U.S. Census Bureau Focus Group: Reminder

Dear [**PARTICIPANT'S NAME**]:

This is a reminder that your focus group is scheduled for [**DAY**], [**DATE**], from [**START TIME**] to [**END TIME**] [**PARTICIPANT TIMEZONE**].

Please use the Microsoft Teams meeting link below to join the focus group 15 minutes before the start time. You may be prompted to download Microsoft Teams in order to join the meeting.

Please note that you will be required to have your video turned on for the duration of the focus group.

Microsoft Teams meeting

Join on your computer

[Click here to join the meeting](#)

Meeting ID: 251 513 515 612

Passcode: bSavo8

*If you have any technical difficulties with joining the Teams meeting, please call Tim Flanigan at 919-485-7743.

As a token of appreciation, you will receive a \$75 electronic gift card for participating. This gift card will be sent to your email address approximately 2-3 weeks after the focus group.

I have also included a copy of the consent form. This document covers your rights as a participant and what to expect during the group discussion. The moderator will go over this form prior to the discussion.

Thank you for your participation!

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]

IN PERSON - SCHEDULING EMAIL – FIRST CONTACT/INVITE

Subject: Availability for Census Bureau Focus Group on 6/25 and Receive \$90 for Your Participation

Hello,

Thank you for your interest in participating in an upcoming focus group for the U.S. Census Bureau. **You are eligible to participate in the in-person focus group, which will take about 90 minutes. You will receive \$90 for participating.** The focus group discussion will be conducted by RTI International, a nonprofit research organization, on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. The purpose of this discussion will be to gather your feedback on issues related to your opinions on government records.

This in-person focus group will be held at **[LOCATION]** on **[DATE/TIME]**

At your earliest convenience, please reply to this email and let me know if you are available to participate in this focus group at this date, time, and location. If you are available and if we still have space in the focus group, I will reach back out to confirm your participation and will provide additional information.

Please let me know if you have any questions or concerns about participating. You may also reach me by phone at 919-541-6040.

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]

IN PERSON - CONFIRMATION EMAIL

Subject: Confirmed for In-Person Focus Group on [DATE], Receive \$90 for Your Participation

Hello,

Thank you for agreeing to participate in an upcoming, in-person focus group for the U.S. Census Bureau. Your focus group is scheduled for **[DATE/TIME]** at **[LOCATION]**. **At your earliest convenience, please reply to this email and let me know if you are still available to participate in this focus group at this date, time, and location.**

As previously communicated, this focus group discussion will be conducted by RTI International, a nonprofit research organization, on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. The purpose of this discussion will be to gather your feedback on issues related to your opinions on government records. You will receive \$90 for your participation.

Your focus group will be held at:

[LOCATION AND ADDRESS]

Please use GPS to navigate to the community center. A staff member will greet you in the lobby. **Please arrive 15 minutes before the start time.** If you are running late, please text Tim Flanigan of RTI International at 919-306-1638, and we will come meet you in the lobby.

Please find attached a copy of the consent form. This document covers your rights as a participant and what to expect during the group discussion. Please review this document before the focus group. The moderator will go over this form prior to the discussion and you will be asked to sign this consent form at the start of the focus group.

If you have any additional questions, or need to reach me before the group discussion, please reply to this email or call 919-541-6040.

Thank you for your participation!

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]

IN PERSON - WEEK BEFORE REMINDER EMAIL

Subject: Reminder for In-Person Focus Group on [DATE] , Receive \$90 for Your Participation

Dear [**PARTICIPANT'S NAME**]:

This is a reminder that you are scheduled to participate in an in-person focus group on **[DATE/TIME]** at **[LOCATION]**. **If you are no longer available to participate on this day and time or at this location, please reply to this email and let us know as soon as possible.**

As previously communicated, this focus group discussion will be conducted by RTI International, a nonprofit research organization, on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. The purpose of this discussion will be to gather your feedback on issues related to your opinions on government records. You will receive \$90 for your participation.

Your focus group will be held at:

[LOCATION AND ADDRESS]

Please use GPS to navigate to the community center. A staff member will greet you in the lobby. **Please arrive 15 minutes before the start time.** If you are running late, please text Tim Flanigan of RTI International at 919-306-1638, and we will come meet you in the lobby.

Please find attached a copy of the consent form. This document covers your rights as a participant and what to expect during the group discussion. Please review this document before the focus group. The moderator will go over this form prior to the discussion and you will be asked to sign this consent form at the start of the focus group.

If you have any additional questions, or need to reach me before the group discussion, please reply to this email or call 919-541-6040.

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]

IN PERSON - DAY BEFORE REMINDER EMAIL

Subject: Reminder for In-Person Focus Group Tomorrow, [DATE], Receive \$90 for Your Participation

Hello,

This is a reminder that you are scheduled to participate in an in-person focus group tomorrow, **[DATE/TIME]** at **[LOCATION]**. **If you are no longer available to participate on this day and time or at this location, please reply to this email and let us know as soon as possible.**

As previously communicated, this focus group discussion will be conducted by RTI International, a nonprofit research organization, on behalf of the U.S. Census Bureau. The purpose of this discussion will be to gather your feedback on issues related to your opinions on government records. You will receive \$90 for your participation.

Your focus group will be held at:

[LOCATION AND ADDRESS]

Please use GPS to navigate to the community center. A staff member will greet you in the lobby. **Please arrive 15 minutes before the start time.** If you are running late, please text Tim Flanigan of RTI International at 919-306-1638, and we will come meet you in the lobby.

Please find attached a copy of the consent form. This document covers your rights as a participant and what to expect during the group discussion. Please review this document before the focus group. The moderator will go over this form prior to the discussion and you will be asked to sign this consent form at the start of the focus group.

If you have any additional questions, or need to reach me before the group discussion, please reply to this email or call 919-541-6040.

Sincerely,

[RECRUITER NAME]